Buddha’s death, when relics were placed inside it. It was this relic-bearing stupa which Ashoka is believed to have changed in an altogether novel way. The Buddhist literature is full of allusions to Ashoka’s ambitious programme of opening up seven of the eight original stupas containing the Buddha’s relics. Remarkably, the Vaishali relic stupa confirms that this was indeed dug into. The dug-up section was not a pit. If it had been, it would have contained lots of waste material. Evidently, an intentional breach was made in the stupa to reach the relics: the relic casket was found in this breach. The breach extended beyond the relic casket to a distance of nearly a metre. Probably, more relic caskets were expected, or the original position of the casket was somewhere near the end of the present breach. In any case, when it was redeposited it came to be placed higher up in the breach, which was then filled up.[47]

Those who had dug into the stupa in the first millennium BCE had done so with the intention of reaching the relics. Their only purpose would have been to remove a large portion of these. Apparently, three-fourths of the relics were removed; the portion left contained no bones but only ash mixed with earth, a punch-marked coin, two glass beads, a conch, and a tiny piece of gold.